

AUDIENCE OF ONE

Written by

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Connor Gaston

FADE IN:

EXT. THE WOODS - WALKING TRAIL - SUNSET

SUPER: AUTUMN

FLASHES of RED and BLUE LIGHT hit the PEACH TREES.

Tear-shaped PEACH BLOSSOMS blow in the wind.

ONE lands gently on the surface of a PUDDLE...

...SPLASH!

A BOOT makes impact.

VARVILLE (V.O.)

Detective. Noun.

(beat)

"A person, especially a police
officer, whose occupation is to
investigate and solve crimes."

Enter Private Detective VARVILLE (60) – A seasoned veteran.
Calm, caring, and curious; like a senior support dog.

He plays with the SLEEVES of his long brown OVERCOAT.

VARVILLE (V.O.)

He who must find both victim and
perpetrator.

(beat)

He who must never miss the signs.

(beat)

Miss the signs, lose everything.

He rolls up a SLEEVE.

Something's wrapped around his wrist.

A RIBBON with a cartoon BLUE BIRD drawn in the center;
branded with the words "BLOO BIRD."

The WIND blows on the RIBBON. He looks. It points FORWARD.

He gives a gentle nod and keeps moving.

As he walks, we slowly turn to see...

...The ENTRANCE GATE to PEACH HILL CEMETERY.

The cemetery sits on a LARGE HILL with ORANGE GRASS, filled
with PEACH TREES. It stretches upward, nearly piercing the
sunset.

VARVILLE (V.O.)
I'll never miss the signs again.

At the hill's BASE...POLICE CARS. An eager gang of OFFICERS.

VARVILLE (V.O.)
It's all right here.
Can't you see?

He looks up. Tear-shaped PEACH BLOSSOMS continue to fall.

VARVILLE (V.O.)
Can't you see the hill is crying?

BEGIN TITLES

AUDIENCE OF ONE

END TITLES

EXT. PEACH HILL CEMETERY - BASE - CONTINUOUS

Varville walks through the GATE. Somebody notices.

CHIEF
Oh, no. No-no-no-no-no-no-n--

This is the CHIEF (40). Big guy with an eye-patch.
He plays with it when he's nervous.

He takes one good look at Varville, and stands his ground.

CHIEF
Nope. Nuh-uh. No PIs. Off you go.

VARVILLE
Varville. Detective. I'm here on
behalf of my client.

CHIEF
I don't care who you're here for.
We're handling it.

Varville looks past the Chief, up the hill.

VARVILLE
Only one guy up there.

Chief raises an eyebrow.

CHIEF
Lucky guess.
(MORE)

CHIEF (CONT'D)
(beat)
Public disturbance call. Likely
another bum. We'll handle--

VARVILLE
He's not a disturbance.

CHIEF
'Scuse me?

Varville gestures to the PATH leading up to the summit.

VARVILLE
Look at the signs.
One fresh set of footprints uphill.
No shoe-marks, either.
He's barefoot.
Look at the pattern of the prints.
They're erratic.
Can't walk in a straight line...

The Chief studies Varville.

VARVILLE (CONT'D)
...He needs help.

Suddenly, the sounds of FOOTSTEPS.

A group of OFFICERS walk by, BATONS in-hand.

They make their way uphill. Eager.

VARVILLE
What are they doing?

CHIEF
Handling it.

VARVILLE
Not happening. I'm going up there.

The RIBBON blows FORWARD. Varville moves with it...

...Stopped by a HAND.

CHIEF
Oi, Mr. Independent. This is
standard procedure.

VARVILLE
Your "standard procedure" is going
to kill him.

CHIEF

Hey. Look at me. We only use the
necessary force to--

VARVILLE

If you freak him out, he's gonna
jump.

CHIEF

You don't know that.

VARVILLE

I do.

A staredown.

The cops continue uphill, exchanging grins.

Varville watches, hands in his pockets.

VARVILLE

My client's one of us, you know.
A deputy, in another life.

CHIEF

...That's quite the breach of
private information--

VARVILLE

He's got this kid, right?
A daughter. Beautiful stuff.
More and more though...
...she becomes this nuisance.
'Till she's kicked out of the house
the day she's eighteen.

(beat)

So, there she is: Broken bottles...
...stumbling footsteps.
Fucked out of her mind, singing
"Bloo Bird" on the highway bridge.
Dad gets a call. Here we go again.
But this time, he's had it.
"That's it," he says to himself.
"Sweetheart, you're a lost cause."
He rallies up his boys in blue,
And they do what they always do.
They handle it.

CHIEF

You bet your ass they do.

A pause.

Chief watches the boys go higher.

CHIEF
So where's she at now?

VARVILLE
Right here.

Varville holds up the BLOO BIRD RIBBON.

Silence.

VARVILLE
Tell me, patchy.
(beat)
You gonna turn a blind eye to this?

The boys look back down the hill, keeping an eye on Chief.

Halfway to the top. Batons ready, smiles growing...

...A HAND raises. It's Chief. The boys exchange looks.

Back down they come. Chief turns to Varville.

CHIEF
You.
(beat)
...Ten minutes.

The WIND blows. The RIBBON points FORWARD.

Varville makes his way uphill.

EXT. PEACH HILL CEMETERY - PATHWAY TO SUMMIT - CONTINUOUS

VARVILLE (V.O.)
Everyone loves *Bloo Bird*.
She did more than anyone.
(beat)
Every morning, this singin' little
puppet pops up on TV with a new
mystery. Kids help her solve it.
(beat)
The great thing about *Bloo Bird*?
She points to the signs.

The RIBBON stops moving.

Varville STOPS. He looks around.

Everywhere...Ordered rows of TOMBSTONES stretch up the hill.

A PEACH rests on top of EACH one.

He nods. Halfway to the top now. He makes sure to lose the overcoat. Just a normal civilian now.

Eyes closed. One foot in front of the other...he listens to the WIND...

...a VOICE. Just one. Wait, no.

VARVILLE

Two!?

Varville makes a beeline for the summit.

EXT. PEACH HILL CEMETERY - SUMMIT - CONTINUOUS

He reaches the TOP. He sees it. The source of the voices...

...But only one MAN.

Keep your cool. Hands where the man can see them.

VARVILLE

How we doin' up here?

SARTORI

D-D-Do you mind!? We were TRYING to have a conversation!

Varville is officially lost.

From behind his back, the MAN reveals...a *SOCK PUPPET*?! Say hello to SOCKY, kids! White wool, red trim, crudely-glued-on googly eyes. Ain't he the sweetest?

Despite his disbelief, Varville keeps the ball rolling.

VARVILLE

(with a friendly wave)

Graveskeeper here! Closin' time.

SARTORI

You mean G-G-G-Groundskeeper!?

VARVILLE

(hesitant)

...That's me. And you?

SARTORI

I-I-I...I'm--

SOCKY

SIMONE SARTORI! The very same!

VARVILLE
(beat)
...The same as who?

SOCKY
The same as ME!

Put your hands together for SIMONE SARTORI (60) -
dishevelled, barefoot, sporadic. He's got a chronic stutter
that comes and goes...but SOCKY doesn't.

VARVILLE
(gesturing to the
tombstones)
We got an early close tonight.
Gotta remove all those damn
peaches...

SARTORI
(panicked)
D-D-DON'T TOUCH THE P-PEACHES! NO
NO NO NO N--

SLAP!

SOCKY
Get a hold of yourself, man! Your
ol' pal SOCKY's got everything
under control...

Sartori approaches Varville. Socky slowly gets up in
Varville's face and...

SOCKY
...BOO!

Varville chuckles.

Socky is STUNNED. He retreats to Sartori's ear.

SOCKY
This guy isn't phased at *all*.

SARTORI
S-S-Should we hear him out?

SOCKY
No. He's gonna hear us out.

VARVILLE
You can tell me all about it as
we're leaving. Sound good?

SOCKY
We can't leave!

VARVILLE
Why not?

SARTORI
MARIA!

VARVILLE
Maria?

SOCKY
Maria.

Silence.

Socky looks to the very edge of the hilltop, dead-center.

A single tombstone.

Maria Valencia Sartori.

***"My darling peach, for only four years.
My blossom, for eternity."***

PEACH BLOSSOMS blow.

VARVILLE (V.O.)
Bloo Bird...is this why you've
brought me here?

Sartori crawls behind her TOMBSTONE. Socky POPS UP over-top.

VARVILLE
Mister, I'm sorry for your loss...

Varville calmly approaches.

VARVILLE (CONT'D)
...But I still got a job to do.
Come back tomorrow after work or
something.

Socky gets up in Varville's face again.

SOCKY
Work!? Hah! No work out there for
guys like us anymore! Nothin' since
that *BLOO BITCH* fucked the market!

Socky hangs his head.

SOCKY (CONT'D)
 No one ever watched us...
 ...No one ever cared.

SARTORI
 (behind the tombstone)
 Except for her.

A BLOSSOM falls on Socky's head. He shakes it off.

Socky disappears behind Maria's tombstone again.

This case is not normal. Varville considers his options.

VARVILLE
 ...Well, as they say in the
 business: "The show must go on."

Socky pops up.

SOCKY
 What'd you just say?

VARVILLE
 The show must go on.

SOCKY
 (beat)
 ...A moment.

Socky goes back behind the tombstone.

The two of them bicker. Whispers...Murmurs...

...ZOOM! Back up in Varville's face!

SOCKY
 Welcome, my fine and handsome
 patron! Welcome to the greatest
 show of your--

Socky's EYE falls off.

SOCKY (CONT'D)
 ...Can you get that?

Varville carefully puts it back on.

SOCKY (CONT'D)
 Welcome to the greatest show of
 your life!

A CASSETTE plays a circus-like WALTZ from behind the GRAVE.

Varville looks back down to the boys. They're pissed.

SOCKY (CONT'D)

(singing)

One late au-tumn eve-ning,/
She wand-ered up-hill./
We told her they're gone now,/
But she see's them still./
Mar-i-a, we can't go./
We can't go un-til,/
Your fath-er has ta-ken his pills!//

EXT. PEACH HILL CEMETERY - BASE - CONTINUOUS

OFFICER

(to Chief)

You hearin' this shit?

A TUNE from uphill. Chief turns his head to the summit.

CHIEF

...What in the f--

EXT. PEACH HILL CEMETERY - SUMMIT - CONTINUOUS

As the next verse begins, Socky turns away from Varville...

...and sings DIRECTLY to Sartori.

SOCKY

(singing)

Mar-i-a you ras-cal,/
You've left out the gate!//
You know that the sun goes down,/
Just af-ter eight!//
No bro-thers! No sis-ters!//
No mo-ther at home!//
Where's god-damn old Dad?//
Play-ing pup-pets a-lone!//

Sartori is nervous. The music gets LOUDER.

Varville's expression grows heartbroken...and worried.

EXT. PEACH HILL CEMETERY - BASE - CONTINUOUS

One OFFICER has had it. He pulls a GUN from his holster.

He walks up. The others follow suit.

Chief looks to his watch. Hesitating...hesitating...

CHIEF

HEY.

(MORE)

CHIEF (CONT'D)
(beat)
...Only one goes.

The group abides, falling back. The lone OFFICER presses on.

EXT. PEACH HILL CEMETERY - SUMMIT - CONTINUOUS

SOCKY
(singing)
Mar-i-a it's sca-ry,/
A-lone with the graves!/
Mar-i-a, you head-ache,/
Why can't you be-have?!/

SOCKY (CONT'D)
(singing)
She told me, they're lone-ly,/
For com-fort, they'd reach!/

That's why on that night,/
She went up.../
And she'd.../
Go put a.../

PEACH! ON! EACH!/
FOR EV-EN THE DEAD,/
NEED! A FRIEND!/
SHE PUT A,/
PEACH! ON! EACH!/
THEY'LL NE-VER BE,/
LONE-LY AGAIN!/
~~~~~

## A STORM of PEACH BLOSSOMS!

Socky takes Sartori for a DANCE around the summit.

VARVILLE  
Sartori...Where are you going!?

SOCKY (CONT'D)  
(singing)  
SHE PUT A,/   
PEACH! ON! EACH!/  
MY DAR-LING THE PAIN,/   
NEV-ER ENDS!/  
(beat)  
YOUR DAD'S A BUFF-OON!/  
BUT HE'LL BE THERE SOON!/  
JUST HOLD ON 'TILL THEN!/  
[SFX: MUSIC]

Sartori and Socky waltz toward the CLIFF.

Varville SPRINTS.

VARVILLE  
 (shouting over the wind)  
 SARTORI, WAIT! PLEASE...  
 (beat)  
 ...I UNDERSTAND!

SOCKY  
 (maniacally)  
 TALK TO THE HAND, GROUNDSKEEPER!  
 THE SHOW MUST GO ON!

Varville is taken aback; his own logic used against him.

Five steps away from the ledge...four...three...two...

VARVILLE  
 (screaming)  
 ...I DEMAND AN ENCORE!

The music STOPS.

Sartori stares down the cliff. Socky stares down Varville.

SOCKY  
 Oh, you want more, do ya?

Socky tilts his head.

SOCKY (CONT'D)  
 ...How about some improv?

VARVILLE  
 Now we're talking! I'll start us  
 off--

The music is BACK. The waltz RAGES.

SOCKY  
 Saaaaaaaaaaaaay...

Socky looks Sartori DEAD IN THE EYES.

SOCKY (CONT'D)  
 Here's one for ya, puppet man.

Sartori looks back in sheer terror.

SOCKY (CONT'D)  
 So a four-year-old girl walks off  
 of a cliff...  
 (beat)  
 ...And Dad's *nowhere* to be found!

SARTORI  
 (angry, scared)  
 I...I-I don't like that punchline--

SOCKY  
**BECAUSE IT'S NOT A FUCKING JOKE.**

Socky STRANGLES Sartori.

Varville GRABS them both. He drags them away from the edge.

Sartori grabs his WRIST. Socky sees it.

The BLOO BIRD RIBBON.

SOCKY  
 Oh, this is just RICH.

Socky RIPS the RIBBON off of Varville. He THROWS IT AWAY.

It BLOWS toward the CLIFF, seconds away from the edge.

With Sartori pinned down, Varville watches in desperation.

Suddenly...FOOTSTEPS from downhill. It's the OFFICER.

A CHOICE: Save Sartori, or save the RIBBON.

Varville watches the RIBBON. He unhands Sartori...

...and RUSHES the OFFICER.

EXT. PEACH HILL CEMETERY - PATHWAY TO SUMMIT - CONTINUOUS

The OFFICER is taken aback. He hesitates to shoot.

Varville TACKLES. They ROLL DOWN the HILL.

CHIEF  
 Are you fucking kidding me!?

The boys BOLT toward them.

Varville snags the officer's GUN.

He unloads and tosses the MAGAZINE.

With the officer down...He SPRINTS for the SUMMIT.

EXT. PEACH HILL CEMETERY - SUMMIT - CONTINUOUS

Varville arrives, but from out of nowhere...

...A CHANTING of VOICES...but not from the CASSETTE.

It is a graveyard, after all.

SOCKY  
(chanting in rhythm)  
GONE! GONE! YOUR AUDIENCE OF ONE!

Three steps away from the edge.

SOCKY (CONT'D)  
GONE! GONE! YOUR AUDIENCE OF ONE!

Two.

SOCKY (CONT'D)  
GONE! GONE! YOUR AUDIENCE OF ONE!

One.

SOCKY (CONT'D)  
GONE! GONE! GONE!

SARTORI  
Gone.

Silence.

SLOW MOTION: Varville rushes desperately to the cliff.

The cops rush through the top of the summit.

Sartori takes his final bow.

He falls backward with Socky. Open arms.

Before he's gone...he takes one last look.

His final audience.

Varville.

The cops.

Maria.

CUT TO:

OVER BLACK.

VARVILLE (V.O.)  
*Man. Noun.*  
(beat)  
He who can see the signs,  
And lose everything all the same.

CUT TO:

EXT. PEACH HILL CEMETERY - BASE - MORNING

VARVILLE (V.O.)  
He who can be both victim and  
perpetrator.

Snowy footsteps through peachless graves...

...Varville walks to the summit.

EXT. PEACH HILL CEMETERY - SUMMIT - CONTINUOUS

Not a footprint in the snow. Untouched. Lonely.

He lights a cigarette and walks through the middle.

He approaches the cliff's edge.

A familiar snowy tombstone. Blossoms hold on tight.

He sits down beside it.

VARVILLE (V.O.)  
I couldn't save them.  
(beat)  
But even if I had...

He wipes the snow and blossoms away.

VARVILLE (V.O.)  
...Would it have kept the bird from  
singing?  
(beat)  
Would it have stopped the hill from  
crying?  
(beat)  
I don't have the answers.  
(beat)  
But no matter what...  
(beat)  
...I'll keep moving *forward*.

The freed blossoms drift away in the wind.

He reaches into his coat pocket, and out it comes.

With care, he rests it on top of the tombstone.

*Peach.*

FADE OUT.